

From Manager to *Director*.

Ten steps, two to five years. The jump is not a harder version of your current job — it is a **change of category**. Managers are paid to deliver. Directors are paid to originate, own revenue and pull the whole firm onto an account. Everything below is built around that single discontinuity.

Manager	YOU ARE HERE
Senior Manager	THE WALL · 2-4 YRS
Director	THE TARGET
Associate Partner	2-4 yrs
Partner	elected

YEAR 0 - 1 · POSITION	YEAR 1 - 3 · BUILD	YEAR 3 - 5 · CONVERT
Be named, be narrow Declare the ambition, choose the niche, recruit the people who will argue for you. Steps 1-3.	Move the mix, build the book Convert delivery hours into origination hours and revenue that carries your name. Steps 4-7.	Make the case unarguable Evidence, headroom, timing — and a hard review date you actually honour. Steps 8-10.

1

DECLARE

Say it out loud, in writing, this cycle

Ambition kept private does not exist. Put **Director** into your LEAD goals, say it to your counsellor and your service-line leader in the same month, and ask the one question most people avoid: **what specifically is missing?** A pipeline you are not named in never considers you — and roughly 60% of EY partner appointments come from inside, so the pipeline is real.

Ask for the gap list. Get it in writing.

2

NARROW

Own one intersection, not five

Pick a **sector × capability** pairing tight enough that you are the first call in the firm — not "data", but "AI assurance for insurers". Directors are bought, not applied for: the market must ask for you by name. Generalists are useful at Manager and invisible at Director, because breadth cannot be sold, only depth can.

Target: top-3 recognised name in one niche

3

SPONSOR

Recruit the person who spends capital on you

A mentor gives you advice; a **sponsor argues for you in rooms you will never enter** — that is the trapdoor that opens. Sponsored people are ~23% more likely to be promoted and earn ~12% more. Then widen it: one advocate is a single point of failure. Build three to five partners who can each quote a real number you produced.

1 sponsor + 3-5 partners who can cite your numbers

4

MIX

Move from 80/20 delivery to 60/40 by year two

Being superb at delivery is **the single most common way to get trapped in it**. The firm has every incentive to keep you billing; nobody will hand you origination time. Block it like a client meeting, defend it like one, and accept that the skills that made you an excellent Manager are not the ones now being assessed.

~2 days a week on origination by end of Y2

5

REVENUE

Get a number with your name on it

Directors are judged on **owned revenue and pipeline**, not effort or excellence. Move your language — and your reality — from "I delivered on that account" to "that account is mine". Track origination, managed revenue and conversion monthly — Director bands commonly sit near ~\$1.75m of managed revenue with a matching cross-sell target.

Own the P&L of one account or capability

6

CROSS-SELL

Bring the whole firm, not your team

The distinguishing Director test is whether you can pull **Tax, Consulting, Strategy & Transactions and Assurance** into your accounts. Learn the neighbouring service lines well enough to recognise their work inside your client's problems — then make the introduction before they ask. Cross-sell is the metric that separates a very good Senior Manager from a Director.

3+ service lines introduced per key account

7

BENCH

Build the person who replaces you

You cannot be promoted out of a seat **nobody else can fill**. Grow two Managers who can run delivery without you, and let them be seen doing it in front of partners. Successor risk is a quiet, rarely-stated reason strong cases get deferred a year — remove it before anyone has to raise it.

2 named successors, proven on live engagements

8

CASE

Write the business case three years early

Submission windows are often a **single week** — the case cannot be written then, only retrieved. Keep a live one-pager and lead every line with attribution: "Led the pricing review that recovered £4.2m in margin", not "was involved in". Committees allocate you less credit than you assume, so claim precisely and name your supporters.

Refresh quarterly, before every counsellor conversation

9

HEADROOM

Go where the firm is short, not where it is crowded

Your personal case is only half the decision. The firm must believe **the seat pays for itself**. Aim at demand the leadership has already funded — AI, energy transition, private capital, regulatory change — or a geography willing to open a new Director slot. Mobility converts cases that merit alone will not.

Choose a practice with a gap, not a queue

10

DEADLINE

Set a decision date and honour it

Give it **two full promotion cycles** after you are formally in the pipeline. If you are not nominated, not sponsored, and the answer never becomes specific, that is the answer. A lateral move into a rival at the next grade is the standard accelerant, and it resets both the personal and the business case at once.

Hard review point: two cycles, then decide

GATE 1 - PERSONAL CASE Can you do the job? Delivery excellence, ratings, leadership, a visible niche. Necessary, and on its own never sufficient.	GATE 2 - BUSINESS CASE Does the seat pay for itself? Owned revenue, pipeline, cross-sell, a market with funded headroom.	GATE 3 - POLITICAL CASE Who argues for you in the room? One sponsor with capital, several partners who can quote your numbers.
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